



Presented By:
Gurkhali FC



OFFICIAL 7-A-SIDE FOOTBALL RULEBOOK

1. Competition Identity & Purpose

ABOUT THE COMPETITION

The Grace Dashain Cup is a community-focused 7-a-side football competition presented in the spirit of sporting excellence, inclusion and respect. These regulations establish a clear and consistent framework for teams, players, officials and organisers.

1.2 What this rulebook covers

- Match conditions, playing requirements and restart procedures.
- Squad registration, player eligibility and the competition's Premier Player limit.
- Equipment, substitutions, goalkeeper restrictions and disciplinary procedures.
- Forfeits, late arrival, interruptions, protests and other competition administration.
- The responsibilities of teams, match officials and the competition committee.

1.1 Status of this rulebook

- This rulebook forms part of the participation requirements for the competition and should be read together with the tournament Terms and Conditions and the completed team registration.
- If there is any inconsistency between this rulebook and the Terms and Conditions, the Terms and Conditions prevail to the extent of the inconsistency.

1.3 Authority of the competition committee

- The competition committee is responsible for administering these regulations and resolving matters not expressly covered.
- The committee may issue reasonable directions to protect safety, fairness and the orderly conduct of the tournament.
- Where a rule is unclear, the committee's interpretation shall apply for the purposes of the competition.

GUIDING PRINCIPLE

The rules are designed to keep the tournament competitive while protecting player safety and the integrity of the competition.

2. Match-Day Snapshot

Item	Competition Standard
Format	7-a-side
Players on field	6 outfield + 1 goalkeeper
Minimum to start/continue	5 players
Maximum registered for a match	12 players
Rolling substitutes	Up to 3 substitutes at one time
Ball	Size 5
League & Knockout match	10 minutes each half / 20 minutes total
Finals	15 minutes each half / 30 minutes total
Offside	Not used
Yellow card	2-minute temporary dismissal
Red card	Dismissal for remainder of match + 1-match suspension
Standard forfeit	3–0
Points system	Win 3, draw 1, loss 0

Tiebreak order	Goal difference, goals scored, head-to-head result, then penalty kicks
Drawn knockout match	Decided by penalty kicks unless the committee announces otherwise before the match
Key eligibility rule	No more than 3 NT Premier League players registered in the squad
Player registration	Only players on the official registered squad may play; no emergency additions
Substitution procedure	Rolling substitutions only with referee control; sent-off players cannot be replaced
Restarts	Throw-ins from touchline; free kicks are indirect unless referee decides otherwise
Slide tackles	Not permitted; referee may penalise even if no contact occurs
Goalkeeper rules	No handling deliberate back-pass; no direct kick beyond halfway after catching, except drop-kick
Team conduct	Teams are responsible for players, officials, supporters and guests
Venue and sponsorship	Venue rules apply; no unauthorised advertising, selling, banners or marquees

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QUICK REFERENCE

All teams should ensure their players understand the eligibility, discipline and goalkeeper provisions before the first match. Ignorance of a competition rule does not remove responsibility for complying with it.

3. Playing Area, Goals & Ball

3.1 Pitch layout

- Matches will be played on a rectangular field suitable for 7-a-side football and smaller than a full-size association football pitch.
- The playing area will be clearly marked with a halfway line and centre mark.
- A defined penalty area and goal area shall be provided at each end.
- Corner areas shall be marked so that corner kicks can be taken from the appropriate location.
- The final pitch dimensions and markings may be adjusted by the organisers to suit the approved venue, provided the field remains safe and appropriate for 7-a-side play.

3.2 Goals

- Goals shall be appropriate for 7-a-side football and smaller than standard full-size football goals.
- Goals and nets must be safely secured before play begins.

3.3 Match ball

- A regulation Size 5 football shall be used.
- The referee or competition officials may reject a ball that is damaged, unsafe or unsuitable for play.

SAFETY FIRST

The organiser and referee may delay or suspend play if the pitch, goals or equipment create an unsafe playing environment.

4. Teams, Squad Registration & Substitutions

4.1 Matchday numbers

- A team fields seven players when at full strength: one goalkeeper and six outfield players.
- A side must have at least five eligible players available to begin or continue a match.
- If a team falls below five players, the referee may stop the match, and the competition committee may apply the relevant forfeit provisions.

4.2 Squad limit

- A maximum of twelve players may be listed for a team's matchday squad.
- Only players recorded on the official matchday list may take part.

4.3 Rolling substitutions

- Substitutions are rolling, allowing players to leave and return during the match.
- A team may have no more than three substitutes available at the same time.
- Players entering or leaving the field must do so in accordance with the referee's instructions and without gaining an unfair advantage.
- A player who has been sent off cannot be replaced for the purpose of restoring the team's full playing strength.

4.4 No emergency additions

- A player cannot be added to the matchday squad because another registered player is injured, absent or unavailable.
- Managers, coaches and other team officials cannot enter the field as players.

5. Player Eligibility & Premier Player Classification

CORE ELIGIBILITY REQUIREMENT

Each squad may contain no more than three Premier Players, regardless of the total number of players listed.

5.1 Who may play

- Only players who have been properly registered for the competition may participate.
- Team officials, including managers and coaches, are not eligible to take a player's place.

5.2 Premier Player definition

- For this tournament, a Premier Player is any player who has featured in **five or more** official matches in the Northern Territory Premier League 2026 including Australia Cup 2026.

5.3 The three-player ceiling

- A team may list no more than three Premier Players in its matchday squad, regardless of the total number of players listed.
- The Premier Player limit applies to the submitted matchday squad and cannot be avoided by leaving a Premier Player off the field at a particular time.

5.4 Responsibility of teams

- Each team is responsible for checking the eligibility of its players before submitting a matchday squad.
- If eligibility is challenged, the team must provide evidence requested by the competition committee, which may include player identification, registration records or competition history.
- An eligibility concern should be raised with competition officials as soon as reasonably possible and, unless the committee allows otherwise, before the next match involving the relevant team.
- The competition committee will determine eligibility challenges for the purposes of the tournament.

5.5 Consequences of an ineligible player

- If an ineligible player participates, the match will ordinarily be recorded as a 3–0 loss against the offending team unless the competition committee determines that another outcome is required for fairness or competition integrity.
- The competition committee may impose additional disciplinary measures depending on the circumstances.

IMPORTANT

Eligibility is based on the registered matchday squad. Removing a Premier Player from the field does not cure a squad that exceeds the permitted Premier Player limit.

6. Kit, Equipment & Match Officials

6.1 Player equipment

- Players must wear suitable football clothing, properly fitted shin guards and footwear appropriate to the playing surface and any venue restriction.
- Hard casts, splints, jewellery or other items considered dangerous by the referee must not be worn unless the referee is satisfied they are safe.
- Teams should wear matching or clearly identifiable colours.

6.2 Colour clash

- If the referee determines that team colours cannot be clearly distinguished, a coin toss will decide which team changes or wears bibs.

6.3 Referee

- The competition committee appoints referees for matches.
- A referee must not officiate a match involving a team with which the referee is connected, unless the committee determines that no practical alternative is available and both teams are informed.
- The referee is responsible for controlling the match and applying the competition rules.

- The referee may stop, delay or abandon play where required for safety, misconduct or other legitimate match-control reasons.
- Decisions made by the referee during the match are final, subject to any competition process specifically provided in this rulebook.

7. Match Timing & Starting the Game

7.1 Match duration

- League matches consist of two 10-minute halves, giving a scheduled playing time of 20 minutes.
- Final matches consist of two 15-minute halves, giving a scheduled playing time of 30 minutes.
- The referee controls the official match clock and determines stoppages where appropriate.

7.2 Kick-off

- The match begins from the centre mark after the referee signals for play to start.
- The team winning the pre-match choice determines the relevant kick-off option in accordance with the referee's direction.
- After a goal, the team that conceded restarts play from the centre.

7.3 Half-time and change of ends

- Teams change ends at half-time unless the organiser or referee directs otherwise.

8. Ball Status, Scoring & Restarts

8.1 Ball in play

- The ball remains in play unless the whole of the ball has crossed a touchline or goal line, or the referee has stopped playing.

8.2 Goal

- A goal counts only when the entire ball passes over the goal line between the goalposts and beneath the crossbar, provided no infringement has occurred.

8.3 No offside

- **NO OFFSIDE**
The Grace Dashain Cup does not use an offside rule. Players may position themselves beyond the last defender, subject to the normal requirements of fair play and other offences.

8.4 Throw-ins

- When the ball completely crosses a touchline, the opposing team restarts play with a throw-in.
- The throw-in is taken from approximately the point where the ball left the field, as directed by the referee.

8.5 Goal kicks

- When the attacking team last touches the ball before it crosses the defending team's goal line without a goal being scored, play restarts with a goal kick.

8.6 Corner kicks

- A corner is awarded when the defending team last touches the ball before it crosses its own goal line and no goal is scored.
- The ball is placed within the appropriate corner area before the kick is taken.

9. Fouls, Free Kicks & Penalty Kicks

9.1 Fouls

- The referee may award a free kick for offences such as kicking, attempting to kick, tripping, pushing, holding, charging unfairly or deliberately handling the ball.
- The referee may also penalise reckless, dangerous or unsporting challenges even where the specific action is not listed.

9.2 Slide tackles

- **SLIDE TACKLES ARE NOT PERMITTED**
A player must not make a sliding tackle. The referee may penalise a slide tackle regardless of whether contact with an opponent occurs.

9.3 Free-kick procedure

- Free kicks are normally taken from the location of the infringement, unless the referee requires another position under these regulations.
- Opponents must move back to the distance directed by the referee.
- Unless the referee determines that a different restart applies, free kicks in this competition are indirect.

9.4 Penalty kicks

- A penalty is awarded when an offence punishable by a direct free kick occurs inside the offending team's penalty area.
- The kick is taken from the designated penalty mark.
- All players other than the kicker and goalkeeper must remain in the positions directed by the referee.
- The goalkeeper must remain on the goal line until the kick is taken, subject to the referee's instructions.

10. Goalkeeper Regulations

10.1 Handling area

- The goalkeeper may use the hands within their own penalty area, except where a specific restriction in this section applies.

10.2 Deliberate teammate pass

- A goalkeeper must not pick up or handle a ball deliberately kicked to them by a teammate.
- The goalkeeper may play such a ball with the feet.
- If the goalkeeper handles a deliberate back-pass, the opposing team receives an indirect free kick from the place of the infringement, subject to the referee's direction.

10.3 Distribution after catching

- After taking possession with the hands, the goalkeeper must not kick the ball directly beyond the halfway line using a conventional kick.
- A drop-kick is permitted and may travel beyond halfway.
- The goalkeeper may also throw, roll, bounce or play the ball short to a teammate.
- A breach of the direct-kick distribution restriction results in an indirect free kick for the opposition from the halfway line.

10.4 Fair distribution

- The goalkeeper must release the ball without deliberately delaying the match. The referee may take action where distribution is used to waste time.

11. Disciplinary Code

11.1 Yellow card — temporary dismissal

- A player receiving a yellow card under the tournament's temporary-dismissal system leaves the field for two minutes.
- During the temporary dismissal, the player's team plays with one fewer player.
- The player may return only after the two-minute period has elapsed and the referee authorises the return.
- The referee may record repeated misconduct and may escalate disciplinary action where appropriate.

11.2 Red card — sending-off

- A player shown a red card is removed from the match and cannot return.
- The team continues the match with one fewer player.
- A red-carded player receives an automatic one-match suspension, subject to any additional sanction imposed by the competition committee.

11.3 Fighting and violent conduct

- **ZERO TOLERANCE**
Fighting, physical confrontation or violent conduct is treated as a serious tournament offence. The priority is player safety and maintaining a respectful competition environment.
- Any player involved in fighting or violent physical conduct may be immediately sent off by the referee.
- The incident will be referred to the competition committee.
- Before imposing a suspension for the remainder of the tournament, the committee will give the player and team a short opportunity to be heard where practicable.
- The committee's decision is final for competition purposes.
- The affected team must continue with the players remaining after the dismissal.
- The competition committee may impose further sanctions where necessary.

11.4 Team responsibility

- Teams are responsible for the behaviour of their players, officials, supporters and guests and must cooperate with referees, organisers, volunteers and venue staff.
- Abusive, threatening or intimidating behaviour towards referees, opponents, organisers, volunteers, venue staff or other teams may lead to disciplinary action.
- The committee may require any player, official, supporter or guest to leave the venue where necessary for safety, order or compliance with venue requirements.

12. Corners, Throw-Ins & General Playing Procedures

12.1 Restarts

- All restarts must be taken promptly and from the location directed by the referee.
- The referee may require a restart to be retaken where the procedure has not been correctly followed.

12.2 Fair play

- Players must not deliberately distract, obstruct or unfairly delay an opponent taking a restart.
- The referee may add disciplinary action for repeated time-wasting or unsporting conduct.

12.3 Match control

- Players and team officials must follow reasonable instructions from the referee and competition officials.
- Only authorised team personnel may occupy the designated team area.

13. Match Interruptions & Rescheduling

13.1 Reasons for interruption

- A match may be suspended or stopped because of severe weather, lighting failure, unsafe playing conditions, venue or facility problems, or another serious technical issue.
- The referee may stop play immediately where player safety is at risk.

13.2 Restarting an interrupted match

- Where possible on the day, an interrupted match will be resumed from the point of interruption.
- The committee may shorten halves, move fixtures, suspend play or abandon a match required by weather, safety, venue conditions or scheduling.
- If a group-stage match cannot be completed, the committee may allow the score to stand, record a draw or determine another result necessary for competition fairness.
- If a knockout match cannot be completed and a result is required, the committee may direct that the match be decided by penalty kicks.
- Teams must comply with the committee's match-interruption decision.

13A. Competition Format, Points & Knockout Matches

13A.1 Competition format

- The committee will confirm the format of the tournament, number of groups, allocation of teams, number of matches per team and finals structure before the draw is issued.
- The published draw will identify how teams progress from the group stage to the knockout stage.

13A.2 Points and standings

- Group-stage standings are determined by three points for a win, one point for a draw and no points for a loss.
- If teams are level on points, positions are decided by goal difference, then goals scored, then head-to-head result, then penalty kicks if required.
- If a team withdraws or forfeits during the group stage, the committee may determine how recorded results affect the standings to preserve fairness and competition integrity.

13A.3 Drawn knockout matches

- Unless the committee announces extra time before the match, a drawn knockout match proceeds directly to penalty kicks.
- Each team takes an equal number of initial penalty kicks as directed by the committee. If scores remain level, sudden death penalties continue until one team scores and the other misses after an equal number of kicks.
- Only players eligible and available at the end of the match may take part in the shoot-out.
- If teams finish with different numbers of eligible players, the team with more players must reduce its penalty-taker list to match the lower number.

14. Late Arrival, Forfeits & Rule Breaches

14.1 Arrival requirement

- Teams must be at the venue, ready to play and able to provide their matchday squad at the scheduled kick-off time.
- A ten-minute grace period applies after the scheduled kick-off.
- If a team has not arrived or cannot field the required playable team within the grace period, the match may be declared a forfeit.

14.2 Forfeit result

- A forfeited match is recorded as a 3–0 victory for the opposing team.
- The competition committee may impose additional consequences where the circumstances justify them.

14.3 Other breaches

- A breach not specifically addressed elsewhere in this rulebook may be dealt with by the competition committee.
- Unless a different sanction is expressly provided, a serious competition breach may result in a 3–0 forfeit and/or additional disciplinary action.
- The severity of any additional sanction may take into account intent, repeat behaviour, sporting impact and cooperation with organisers.

14A. Safety, First Aid & Heat Management

14A.1 Head injury and concussion

- A player who shows signs of concussion or a suspected head injury must be removed from play immediately.
- The player may not return to play during the event unless the committee accepts appropriate medical clearance. Junior players with suspected concussion must not return to play during the event.

14A.2 Bleeding, first aid and emergency assistance

- A player who is bleeding must leave the field and may not return until the bleeding has stopped and any blood-stained clothing has been changed or made safe.
- First aid will be available at the venue where arranged by the organiser.
- The committee, referee or designated first-aid officer may call emergency services where they consider it necessary.

14A.3 Heat and hydration

- The referee may allow drinks breaks where required by weather, heat or player welfare.
- The committee may shorten, delay or suspend matches in extreme heat or unsafe weather conditions.

15. Competition Integrity & Dispute Handling

15.1 Integrity of the tournament

- Every team is responsible for submitting accurate player and registration information.
- Teams must not deliberately conceal player eligibility information or use an unregistered player.
- Attempts to manipulate results, player status or competition administration may be referred to the competition committee for sanction.

15.2 Match-day concerns

- Concerns about a player's eligibility or a serious rule breach should be raised with the competition officials as soon as reasonably possible.
- The referee controls decisions during the match; the competition committee handles administrative and disciplinary matters outside the referee's immediate match-control role.

15.3 Final authority

- The competition committee's determination on competition administration and disciplinary matters is final for the purposes of the competition.
- Nothing in this rulebook prevents a person or team from exercising any legal right that cannot lawfully be excluded.

15A. Sponsorship, Advertising, Venue Conduct & Junior Players

15A.1 Sponsorship, advertising and branding

- No team, club, player, official or supporter may erect, display, distribute or permit the display of banners, marquees, tents, gazebos, flags, signs, posters, flyers or other promotional material at the venue unless approved by the organiser.
- A team sponsor may be promoted only through branding applied to that team's playing jerseys, unless the organiser gives prior written approval.
- Only official tournament sponsor signage approved by the organiser may be displayed at the venue.
- No person may sell or offer for sale any goods, food or beverages at the venue without prior written approval from the organiser.
- The organiser may remove non-compliant material and may sanction a team for repeated or deliberate breach.

15A.2 Venue conduct

- Teams, officials, players, supporters and guests must comply with venue rules, including any rules about alcohol, glass, smoking, vaping, parking, animals, rubbish and restricted areas.
- A person must not participate while under the influence of alcohol or drugs, and the organiser or referee may prevent that person from taking the field.

15A.3 Junior players

- A player under 18 years of age may not take part unless the organiser has received the required parent or guardian consent and medical information.
- Each junior team must always have a nominated adult team official present at the venue.
- Disciplinary decisions involving junior players must be handled with appropriate regard to player welfare and must include a practical opportunity for the junior player's team official to be heard where possible.

16. Team Acknowledgement & Declaration

By signing below or accepting the rulebook electronically, the team representative confirms that they are authorised to accept this Official Grace Dashain Cup 7-a-side Rulebook on behalf of the team, its players and its officials. The representative confirms that all players and team officials have been given access to the rulebook and will comply with the competition requirements.

The representative further confirms that any junior player has been identified to the organiser and will not take the field until the required parent or guardian consent has been provided. The representative acknowledges that breaches of the rulebook may lead to appropriate action, including a warning, temporary dismissal, sending-off, suspension, match forfeiture, tournament removal or other sanctions determined under the competition regulations.

Team Name

Team Representative

Contact Number

Signature

Date

Competition Official

GRACE DASHAIN CUP

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